

## Elections

In a multi-party democracy, every three to five years voters go to the polls to elect their government, choosing the politicians who will represent them from a list of candidates. Elections are an opportunity for politicians to present their ideas for the government of the country, and for the electorate to debate and consider matters of interest and concern to them. In the past, elections were local, personal affairs, in which candidates for office tried to meet each elector in person. Today, most electioneering is carried out by advertising and television.

### Voting

The electors vote in secret for the candidate of their choice by marking a ballot paper. The ballots are then counted and the winning candidate is elected. In many countries, electors rank candidates in order of preference. A system of proportional representation (PR) then ensures that the candidates with the most preferences are elected.



### Political parties

Political parties are formed to represent particular political beliefs, such as the Socialist Party in France or the Christian Democratic Party in Germany, or to represent particular areas of a country, such as the Scottish Nationalists, who wish to see Scotland become independent from Britain. Political parties are active at local and national levels in getting their supporters out to vote and in attracting new voters to their cause.



Swedish Christian Democratic Party



French Socialist Party

### Politicians

People become politicians for different reasons. Some people stand for election because they believe in serving the public, or have a particular skill that would be useful in government. Others stand to represent a particular political viewpoint. In the USA, the cost of a campaign restricts candidates to those with money.



US Democratic Convention, 1996



### Politics

Politics is the organization of political debate and discussion in a country. That debate can take place in a formal setting as in parliament, or informally. Any subject can be discussed, from major issues such as the economy or international relations, to local issues such as the siting of a new road.

Chamber of the House of Commons, London, UK

## Public pressure

Everyone can play a part in politics, from full-time politicians to individuals who are concerned about a particular issue or event. Apart from elections, individuals can bring pressure to bear on governments, both by participating in public protest, such as strikes and demonstrations, and by joining pressure groups that are set up to campaign for particular issues, such as protecting the environment or civil liberties.



### Protest groups

In order to force an issue into the public view, it is sometimes necessary to take direct action. Recently, protest groups have achieved success against the siting of nuclear weapons and the proposed building of new roads.

### Pressure groups

Pressure groups play an important part in focusing attention on issues of public concern. Environmental pressure groups, such as Greenpeace, raise public awareness on issues of pollution or environmental damage that cross national borders.



Dove bearing olive branch symbolizes hope.

## Political beliefs

Different political beliefs play a large part in determining how a country is governed. Left-wing ideologies, such as communism and socialism, favour a large role for the state acting on behalf of its citizens, while right-wing ideologies, such as capitalism, favour individual action and responsibility by citizens.

### Capitalism

Capitalism is the system in which wealth and profit in the hands of a few people drive the country's economy. Capitalism can lead to great differences in income between rich and poor.



### Fascism

Fascism is the system of government under which total authority resides in the leader of the country, who pursues nationalist and militarist policies. Like other far-right ideologies, fascism glorifies the state for providing strong national leadership.



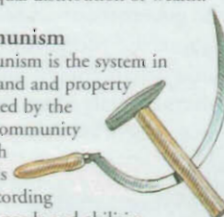
### Socialism

Socialism is the system in which the economy is controlled by the state for the benefit of the whole community. Countries such as the Netherlands and Sweden aim for a more equal distribution of wealth.



### Communism

Communism is the system in which land and property are owned by the whole community and each person is paid according to their needs and abilities. China and North Korea are examples of communist countries.



## Machiavelli

Niccolò Machiavelli (1469–1527) was a civil servant in the Florentine Republic in Italy. He was a realist who observed the political chaos of his times and urged governments to pursue practical, realistic politics rather than lofty political ideals. In his book *The Prince* (1532), he described politics as the art of the possible and pointed out what a government can do rather than what it ought to do.



FIND OUT  
MORE

COLD  
WAR

EUROPE,  
HISTORY OF

EUROPEAN  
UNION

HUMAN  
RIGHTS

LAW

PEACE  
MOVEMENTS

UNIONS,  
TRADE

UNITED  
NATIONS

WARFARE

WOMEN'S  
MOVEMENT